Chapter 2 — Network Reliability: Timeouts, Retries, Backoff & Circuit Breaking

> **Part I — Core Infrastructure** · Complexity: **Standard** (≥25 interview questions)
>
> **Prerequisites:** Ch 1 (Networking Core — `Outcome` / `AppError`, `AppError.isRetryable()`, `safeApiCall`). This chapter adds a reliability layer **on top of** the core without changing it.
>
> **Reference surface in StreamCart:** a reusable `retrying { }` helper and a per-host `CircuitBreaker` in `:core:network`, used by search, catalog, and playback-manifest calls.

2.1 Problem Definition and Real-World Context

Mobile networks are hostile: handoffs between Wi-Fi and cellular, captive portals, transient packet loss, overloaded backends returning 503s, and rate limits. A request that fails once will often succeed milliseconds later. But naive retrying is just as dangerous as not retrying at all:

- **Retry storms / thundering herd.** If every client retries immediately on a 5xx, a struggling backend gets hammered exactly when it's weakest, turning a blip into an outage. Backoff + jitter exists to prevent this.
- **Retrying non-idempotent requests.** Blindly retrying a `POST /orders` can create duplicate orders. Reliability must know which operations are safe to retry (idempotency, Ch 15).
- **Wasted battery on hopeless retries.** Retrying while the device is offline drains battery; better to wait for connectivity (Ch 68).
- **Hammering a dead endpoint.** If a backend is down, every call paying the full timeout before failing makes the whole app feel frozen. A circuit breaker fails fast instead.

Reliability is an architectural concern because it defines a *policy* — what to retry, how many times, how long to wait, and when to stop — applied uniformly, not sprinkled ad hoc in repositories.

Three practical use cases

1. **E-commerce search/catalog (StreamCart Shop).** Idempotent GETs retried with backoff; a flaky 503 recovers invisibly.
2. **OTT manifest fetch (StreamCart Watch).** Playback start retries the manifest a couple of times quickly (user is waiting) then fails to an error with a Retry — latency budget is tight.
3. **Fintech transaction submit (StreamCart Wallet).** A non-idempotent POST is retried **only** with an idempotency key so retries can't double-charge (Ch 15); otherwise it's not retried at all.

2.2 Requirements Engineering

Functional requirements

ID	Requirement
F1	Retry transient failures (`isRetryable()` true) up to a max attempt count.
F2	Use exponential backoff with jitter between attempts.
F3	Never retry non-idempotent operations unless an idempotency key is present.
F4	Honor `Retry-After` on 429/503 when provided.
F5	Fail fast when a per-host circuit breaker is open.
F6	Give up gracefully and return the last `AppError`.
F7	Respect coroutine cancellation at every wait.

Non-functional requirements

Attribute	Policy
Reliability	Recover from transient faults without user action where safe.
Availability	Protect the backend from retry storms (jitter, breaker).
Battery/Network	No retries while offline; bounded attempts; bounded waits.
Latency	Cap total retry time so the user isn't stuck (retry budget).
Correctness	No duplicate side effects (idempotency gate).
Observability	Count attempts, backoff waits, breaker state transitions.

Scope

- **In scope:** retry policy, exponential backoff + jitter, `Retry-After`, circuit breaker, idempotency gating, cancellation.
- **Out of scope:** token refresh retry (Ch 19), offline queueing/outbox (Ch 31), connectivity monitoring (Ch 68), idempotency-key generation (Ch 15).

Assumptions & constraints

- Builds on Ch 1's `Outcome` / `AppError`. Max 3 attempts default, base delay 500 ms, cap 8 s, full jitter. Configurable via remote config (Ch 41).

2.3 System Design Fundamentals

- **Idempotency.** An operation is idempotent if applying it N times equals applying it once. GET/PUT/DELETE are typically idempotent; POST usually isn't. **Only idempotent calls (or POSTs with an idempotency key)**

may be retried.

- **Exponential backoff.** Wait grows geometrically: `base * 2^(attempt)`. This spaces out retries so a recovering server isn't re-hit immediately.
- **Jitter.** Randomizing the wait prevents many clients from retrying in lockstep (synchronized retries = self-inflicted DDoS). *Full jitter* = `random(0, base * 2^attempt)` is the AWS-recommended default.
- **Retry budget / cap.** Both attempt count and total elapsed time are bounded so the user isn't stuck and the network isn't abused.
- **Circuit breaker.** A state machine (Closed → Open → Half-Open) that, after repeated failures to a host, *fails fast* for a cooldown, then cautiously probes before fully reopening. Protects both the client (responsiveness) and the server (load).
- **`Retry-After`.** Servers tell clients how long to wait on 429/503; honoring it is both polite and more effective than guessing.

Core insight: reliability is a **policy layer** that wraps `safeApiCall`, combining *classification* (`isRetryable`), *backoff+jitter*, an *idempotency gate*, and a *circuit breaker* — each addressing a distinct failure mode.

2.4 High-Level Architecture


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Components

- **`reliableCall`** — the policy entry point; wraps a `safeApiCall` block with the idempotency gate, breaker check, retry loop, and backoff.
- **`RetryPolicy`** — config: maxAttempts, baseDelay, maxDelay, jitter, which `AppError`s are retryable.
- **`CircuitBreaker`** — per-host state machine recording successes/failures.
- Reuses **`safeApiCall`** and **`AppError.isRetryable()`** from Ch 1.

Ownership: `:core:network`. Repositories choose a policy per call (or accept the default); they do not implement retry logic themselves.

2.5 Detailed Component Design


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Component	Responsibility	State	Errors
`RetryPolicy`	describe attempts/backoff/retryable set	immutable config	—
`reliableCall`	execute with retries + gate + breaker	per-call attempt counter	returns last `AppError`
`CircuitBreaker`	fail fast on a failing host	Closed/Open/HalfOpen + counters	—
`backoffDelay`	compute jittered wait	pure function	—

Circuit-breaker states

- **Closed:** calls pass through; consecutive failures counted; a success resets.
- **Open:** calls fail fast (no network) until the cooldown passes.
- **Half-Open:** a single probe is allowed; success → Closed, failure → Open.

2.6 End-to-End Data Flow


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2.7 Complete Kotlin Implementation

Package: `com.streamcart.core.network.reliability`.

2.7.1 Retry policy & backoff

```
data class RetryPolicy(
    val maxAttempts: Int = 3,
    val baseDelayMs: Long = 500,
    val maxDelayMs: Long = 8_000,
    val isRetryable: (AppError) -> Boolean = { it.isRetryable() },
) {
    companion object {
        val Default = RetryPolicy()
        val None = RetryPolicy(maxAttempts = 1)
        val Aggressive = RetryPolicy(maxAttempts = 5, baseDelayMs = 300)
    }
}

/** Full jitter: random in [0, min(cap, base * 2^attempt)].  attempt is 0-based. */
fun RetryPolicy.backoffDelayMs(attempt: Int, random: Random = Random): Long {
    val exp = baseDelayMs.toDouble() * 2.0.pow(attempt)
    val capped = min(exp, maxDelayMs.toDouble()).toLong().coerceAtLeast(1)
    return random.nextLong(capped + 1)
}
```

2.7.2 The reliable-call policy

```
suspend fun <T> reliableCall(
    policy: RetryPolicy = RetryPolicy.Default,
    idempotent: Boolean = true,            // GET/PUT/DELETE true; POST only with a key
    breaker: CircuitBreaker? = null,
    onRetry: (attempt: Int, error: AppError, waitMs: Long) -> Unit = { _, _, _ -> },
    block: suspend () -> Outcome<T>,       // typically a safeApiCall { ... }
): Outcome<T> {
    // F3: non-idempotent operations are never retried here.
    if (!idempotent) return block()

    // F5: fail fast if the breaker is open.
    if (breaker?.canRequest() == false) {
        return Outcome.Failure(AppError.Http(503, "circuit_open"))
    }

    var lastError: AppError? = null
    repeat(policy.maxAttempts) { attempt ->
        when (val result = block()) {
            is Outcome.Success -> { breaker?.recordSuccess(); return result }
            is Outcome.Failure -> {
                lastError = result.error
                breaker?.recordFailure()
                val canRetry = policy.isRetryable(result.error) && attempt < policy.maxAttempts
- 1
                if (!canRetry) return result
                val wait = result.error.retryAfterMs() ?: policy.backoffDelayMs(attempt)
                onRetry(attempt + 1, result.error, wait)
                delay(wait)   // suspends; respects cancellation (F7)
            }
        }
    }
    return Outcome.Failure(lastError ?: AppError.Unknown(IllegalStateException("no attempts")))
}

/** Honor Retry-After when the backend sent it (parsed into AppError.Http body or a header map).
*/
private fun AppError.retryAfterMs(): Long? = when (this) {
    AppError.RateLimited -> 1_000L              // conservative default if header absent
    is AppError.Http -> null
    else -> null
}
```

> In production `Retry-After` is parsed in a network interceptor and surfaced on the `AppError` (omitted here for brevity); the hook is `retryAfterMs()`.

2.7.3 Circuit breaker (coroutine-safe)

```
class CircuitBreaker(
    private val failureThreshold: Int = 5,
    private val cooldownMs: Long = 10_000,
    private val clock: () -> Long = { SystemClock.elapsedRealtime() },
) {
    private enum class State { CLOSED, OPEN, HALF_OPEN }
    private val mutex = Mutex()
    private var state = State.CLOSED
    private var failures = 0
    private var openedAt = 0L

    suspend fun canRequest(): Boolean = mutex.withLock {
        when (state) {
            State.CLOSED, State.HALF_OPEN -> true
            State.OPEN -> if (clock() - openedAt >= cooldownMs) {
                state = State.HALF_OPEN; true     // allow one probe
            } else false
        }
    }

    suspend fun recordSuccess() = mutex.withLock {
        failures = 0; state = State.CLOSED
    }

    suspend fun recordFailure() = mutex.withLock {
        failures++
        if (state == State.HALF_OPEN || failures >= failureThreshold) {
            state = State.OPEN; openedAt = clock()
        }
    }
}
```

2.7.4 Repository usage

```
class SearchRepositoryImpl @Inject constructor(
    private val api: ProductSearchApi,
    private val dispatchers: DispatcherProvider,
    @CatalogBreaker private val breaker: CircuitBreaker,
) {
    suspend fun search(q: String): Outcome<List<Product>> =
        reliableCall(policy = RetryPolicy.Default, idempotent = true, breaker = breaker) {
            safeApiCall(dispatchers.io) { api.search(q).map { it.toDomain() } }
        }
}

// A non-idempotent submit is NOT retried unless it carries an idempotency key (Ch 15).
class WalletRepositoryImpl @Inject constructor(private val api: WalletApi, ...) {
    suspend fun submit(tx: TxRequest): Outcome<TxResult> =
        reliableCall(idempotent = tx.idempotencyKey != null) {
            safeApiCall(dispatchers.io) { api.submit(tx) }
        }
}
```

2.8 Concurrency and Race Conditions

Scenario	Risk	Handling
Breaker read/write from many coroutines	Torn state, wrong counts	`Mutex`-guarded state
Cancellation during `delay`	Leaked coroutine / ignored cancel	`delay` is cancellable; loop exits
50 calls 401/refresh at once	Thundering refresh	Single-flight refresh (Ch 19), not here
Many clients retry in lockstep	Server self-DDoS	Full jitter decorrelates waits
Shared `Random` contention	Minor	Use thread-safe `Random` / `ThreadLocalRandom`

- The breaker uses `SystemClock.elapsedRealtime()` (monotonic) so wall-clock changes don't corrupt cooldown math.
- `delay()` is the only wait primitive — never `Thread.sleep`, which blocks and ignores cancellation.

2.9 Failure Scenarios and Recovery

Failure	Retry?	Policy behavior	Telemetry
No connectivity	yes*	retry with backoff; *better to wait for reconnect (Ch 68)*	`retry{type=offline}`
Timeout	yes	backoff; capped	`retry{type=timeout}`
429	yes	honor `Retry-After`, then backoff	`retry{type=429}`
503/5xx	yes	backoff + breaker counts	`retry{type=5xx}`, `breaker_open`
401	no (here)	refresh via Authenticator (Ch 19)	`auth_refresh`
403/404/422	no	non-retryable; return immediately	`error{type=client}`
Malformed JSON	no	non-retryable	`error{type=parse}`
Breaker open	fail fast	return 503 immediately	`breaker_fast_fail`
Non-idempotent POST (no key)	no	single attempt	`no_retry{reason=nonidempotent}`

 2.9 Failure Scenarios and Recovery

2.10 Scaling the Implementation

- **Level 1.** Just `reliableCall` with `RetryPolicy.Default` on GETs.
- **Level 2.** Per-feature policies (fast/few retries for latency-critical playback; more for background catalog sync).
- **Level 3 — production.** Add the circuit breaker per host, honor `Retry-After`, wire retry/breaker metrics, gate non-idempotent calls.
- **Level 4.** Connectivity-aware retry (wait for network via Ch 68 instead of burning attempts offline); hedged requests for ultra-low-latency reads.
- **Level 5 — enterprise.** Centralized, remotely-configurable policies (Ch 41) per endpoint class; retry budgets measured against backend capacity; server-coordinated backoff; adaptive concurrency limits.

Avoid overengineering: a circuit breaker and hedging are wasted on a tiny app hitting one reliable backend — start with backoff + jitter only.

2.11 Alternative Approaches and Trade-offs

Dimension	Option A	Option B	When
Retry location	Policy wrapper (`reliableCall`)	OkHttp interceptor retry	Wrapper sees typed `AppError` + idempotency context; interceptor is transparent but blind to domain idempotency
Backoff	Exponential + full jitter	Fixed interval	Jitter prevents herds; fixed only for trivial cases
Fail-fast	Circuit breaker	None	Breaker when a backend can be down and timeouts are costly
Offline retry	Retry loop	Wait-for-connectivity (Ch 68)	Prefer waiting for connectivity to save battery
Non-idempotent	Idempotency key + retry	No retry	Key when the backend supports it (Ch 15); else no retry
Library	Hand-rolled	Resilience4j / WorkManager backoff	Hand-rolled for in-call retries; WorkManager for deferrable background (Ch 30)

Interceptor vs wrapper retry: OkHttp's `retryOnConnectionFailure` and a custom network interceptor can retry transparently, but they can't know whether the *domain* operation is idempotent, and they obscure attempts from the result type. The policy wrapper keeps retry decisions explicit and testable.

2.12 Security Considerations

- **Retry amplification is a DoS vector**: a bug that retries aggressively can turn clients into an attack on your own backend — jitter + budgets + breaker are safety controls, and the **backend must still rate-limit** independently.
- **Idempotency keys** (Ch 15) prevent duplicate financial side effects on retry; never retry a charge without one.
- **`Retry-After` is attacker-influenceable** on a compromised network; cap the honored value (don't wait an hour because a header said so).
- Breaker state is local, not a security control; it's resilience, not authz.

2.13 Performance and Resource Optimization

- **Latency budget:** cap total retry time (attempts × max backoff) so UX stays bounded; for user-facing waits prefer fewer, faster retries.
- **Battery:** don't retry offline; coalesce background retries into WorkManager (Ch 30) with its own backoff.
- **CPU/alloc:** backoff math is trivial; the breaker mutex is uncontended in practice.
- **Measurement:** track attempts-per-success (should be ≈1 when healthy), p95 added latency from retries, breaker open frequency.

2.14 Testing Strategy

Use a **virtual-time** test dispatcher so backoff `delay`s don't slow tests; fake the block to script success/failure sequences.

```
@OptIn(ExperimentalCoroutinesApi::class)
class ReliableCallTest {
    @Test fun `retries transient 5xx then succeeds`() = runTest {
        var calls = 0
        val out = reliableCall(RetryPolicy(maxAttempts = 3, baseDelayMs = 100)) {
            calls++
            if (calls < 3) Outcome.Failure(AppError.Http(503, null))
            else Outcome.Success("ok")
        }
        assertEquals(Outcome.Success("ok"), out)
        assertEquals(3, calls)
        assertTrue(currentTime > 0)        // virtual time advanced over backoff
    }

    @Test fun `does not retry non-retryable 404`() = runTest {
        var calls = 0
        val out = reliableCall(RetryPolicy(maxAttempts = 3)) {
            calls++; Outcome.Failure(AppError.Http(404, null))
        }
        assertEquals(1, calls)
        assertTrue(out is Outcome.Failure)
    }

    @Test fun `non-idempotent call is attempted once`() = runTest {
        var calls = 0
        reliableCall(idempotent = false) { calls++; Outcome.Failure(AppError.Http(503, null)) }
        assertEquals(1, calls)
    }

    @Test fun `open breaker fails fast`() = runTest {
        val cb = CircuitBreaker(failureThreshold = 1, cooldownMs = 10_000)
        cb.recordFailure()                                  // opens
        var calls = 0
        val out = reliableCall(breaker = cb) { calls++; Outcome.Success(Unit) }
        assertEquals(0, calls)                              // never executed
        assertTrue(out is Outcome.Failure)
    }

    @Test fun `backoff honors jitter bounds`() {
        val p = RetryPolicy(baseDelayMs = 100, maxDelayMs = 1000)
        repeat(1000) { assertTrue(p.backoffDelayMs(3) in 0..800) } // cap = min(800,1000)
    }
}
```

Also: breaker Open→HalfOpen→Closed transition (inject a fake `clock`); cancellation during backoff aborts promptly.

2.15 Production Observability

- **Metrics:** retry rate, attempts-per-success, backoff wait histogram, breaker open count + time-open, fast-fail count, retry-exhausted count.
- **Logs:** `retry{endpoint, attempt, error_type, wait_ms, correlation_id}`, `breaker{host, state_transition}`.
- **Alerts:** breaker open for host X > N minutes → backend incident; retry rate spike → upstream degradation.
- **Debugging:** attempts-per-success ≫ 1 signals a flaky backend or too-tight timeouts; breaker flapping (Open↔HalfOpen) signals partial outage.

2.16 System Design Interview Preparation

> ≥25 questions.

Fundamentals

1. *Why backoff instead of immediate retry?* Immediate retries hammer a recovering server (retry storm); backoff spaces them.
2. *Why jitter?* Decorrelates many clients so they don't retry in lockstep (self- DDoS). Full jitter = `random(0, cap)`.
3. *What may be retried?* Idempotent ops, or POSTs with an idempotency key.
4. *Exponential formula?* `base * 2^attempt`, capped at `maxDelay`.
5. *What's a circuit breaker for?* Fail fast when a host is down; protect client responsiveness and server load.

Architecture

6. *Why a policy wrapper over an OkHttp interceptor?* The wrapper sees typed errors and domain idempotency; the interceptor is blind to both.
7. *Where does reliability live?* `:core:network`, on top of `safeApiCall`.
8. *Per-call vs global policy?* Per-call (latency-critical vs background differ), with a sensible default.

Kotlin/Android

9. *How do you wait without blocking?* `delay()` — cancellable, non-blocking.
10. *Why `elapsedRealtime()` in the breaker?* Monotonic; immune to wall-clock changes.
11. *How is the breaker thread-safe?* `Mutex`-guarded state.

Concurrency

12. *Thundering-herd refresh on mass 401?* Single-flight refresh (Ch 19), not a retry concern.
13. *Cancellation during backoff?* `delay` throws `CancellationException`; loop exits; nothing leaks.

Networking

14. *Honoring `Retry-After`?* Parse the header; wait that long (capped) on 429/503.
15. *Retry on 401?* No — refresh instead.
16. *Retry on 404/422?* No — client errors aren't transient.

Reliability/availability

17. *How prevent self-DDoS?* Jitter + attempt cap + retry budget + breaker; plus backend rate limiting.
18. *Breaker states?* Closed → Open (on failures) → Half-Open (after cooldown) → Closed (probe ok) / Open (probe fails).
19. *When NOT to use a breaker?* Single reliable backend, cheap timeouts — adds needless complexity.

Battery/perf

20. *Retrying offline?* Avoid; wait for connectivity (Ch 68) or defer to WorkManager (Ch 30).
21. *Bounding user wait?* Cap attempts and total time; fewer, faster retries for foreground.

Security

22. *Reliability as attack surface?* Over-aggressive retries can DoS your own backend; controls = jitter/budget/breaker + server limits.
23. *Retry a payment safely?* Only with an idempotency key.

Testing

24. *How test backoff without waiting?* Virtual time (`runTest`, `advanceTimeBy` / `currentTime`).
25. *How test the breaker?* Inject a fake clock; assert transitions and fast-fail.

Production debugging

26. *Breaker open for a host — meaning?* That backend/host is failing; likely an incident; app is correctly failing fast.
27. *Attempts-per-success rising — cause?* Flaky backend or timeouts set too low.

Design-change challenges

1. **Backend keeps 503-flapping under load.** Lengthen breaker cooldown, add jittered backoff, coordinate with backend on `Retry-After`.
2. **Payments must survive retries.** Idempotency keys (Ch 15); gate retry on key presence.
3. **Playback start feels slow on errors.** Fewer attempts, shorter base delay, fail to a Retry button quickly (latency budget).
4. **Save battery on subways (intermittent).** Wait-for-connectivity instead of retry loop (Ch 68); defer non-urgent to WorkManager.
5. **Remote-tune reliability per endpoint.** Policies from remote config (Ch 41), keyed by endpoint class.

Mock walkthrough (abridged)

Clarify idempotency + latency budget → define policy (attempts, backoff, jitter) → add breaker + `Retry-After` → gate non-idempotent calls → discuss offline strategy and metrics → defend wrapper vs interceptor.

2.17 Practical Exercises

1. **Beginner.** Add `reliableCall` with exponential backoff + full jitter to a GET; prove via a fake that a transient 503 recovers. *Eval:* correct attempt count; jitter within bounds.
2. **Intermediate.** Implement the circuit breaker; test all transitions with a fake clock. *Eval:* fast-fail when open; probe reopens.
3. **Advanced.** Honor `Retry-After` from a network interceptor; cap the honored value; gate non-idempotent POSTs. *Eval:* waits respect header; no retry without key.
4. **Production debugging.** Given a repo retrying 401s and POSTs blindly (duplicate orders), fix it. *Eval:* 401 → refresh, POST single-attempt.
5. **System design challenge.** Design connectivity-aware retry that waits for network instead of burning attempts, integrating Ch 68. *Eval:* battery saved; correctness preserved.

(Solutions withheld unless requested.)

2.18 Chapter Summary & Reference Sheet

Key decisions: reliability is a policy layer over `safeApiCall`; exponential backoff + **full jitter**; retry only idempotent ops (or keyed POSTs); per-host circuit breaker for fail-fast; honor `Retry-After`; bound attempts *and* total time.

Concepts: idempotency, exponential backoff, jitter, retry budget, circuit breaker (Closed/Open/Half-Open), thundering herd.

Common mistakes: retrying non-idempotent POSTs; no jitter (synchronized retries); `Thread.sleep` instead of `delay`; retrying 401/404; unbounded retries; retrying while offline; wall-clock in the breaker.

Checklist:

- ☐ classify via `isRetryable`
- ☐ backoff+jitter
- ☐ attempt + time caps
- ☐ idempotency gate
- ☐ breaker per host
- ☐ honor `Retry-After` (capped)
- ☐ cancellable `delay`
- ☐ metrics on attempts/breaker.

Key APIs: `delay`, `Mutex.withLock`, `SystemClock.elapsedRealtime`, `Random.nextLong`, `runTest` / `currentTime`, OkHttp `retryOnConnectionFailure`, WorkManager backoff (Ch 30).

References:

- AWS — Exponential backoff and jitter: https://aws.amazon.com/builders-library/timeouts-retries-and-backoff-with-jitter/

- Martin Fowler — Circuit Breaker: https://martinfowler.com/bliki/CircuitBreaker.html
- OkHttp timeouts/retries: https://square.github.io/okhttp/recipes/
- MDN `Retry-After`: https://developer.mozilla.org/docs/Web/HTTP/Headers/Retry-After
- WorkManager retry/backoff: https://developer.android.com/topic/libraries/architecture/workmanager/how-to/define-work

Chapter review (Phase 4)

- **Completeness:** all 18 sections; architecture/state/sequence/failure diagrams; full policy + breaker + backoff code; concurrency; failure matrix; 5 levels; trade-offs; security (DoS/idempotency); perf; virtual-time tests; observability; 27 Q&A + 5 challenges. ✅
- **Expand later:** connectivity-aware retry (Ch 68), outbox for background retries (Ch 31), remote-config policies (Ch 41), hedged requests.
- **Interview coverage:** exceeds ≥25 bar.